

This celestial map from the 1600s is by Dutch-German cartographer Andreas Cellarius. Exploration and astronomical studies were core facets of Renaissance culture, and astronomy was an important branch of natural philosophy.

The Theban alphabet

The so-called Theban alphabet, a writing system with equivalences to the Latin alphabet, took hold in the occult world during the Renaissance. Often given an original attribution to Honorius of Thebes, a mysterious (and possibly mythical) writer of the medieval period, it was first published in Johannes Trithemius's *Polygraphia* (1500s). Agrippa included it in his work *De occulta philosophia libri tres*—although a later text than *Polygraphia*, this is often considered to be the alphabet's first significant appearance and certainly gave it prominence. Historically, this alphabet was frequently used to keep the content of magical writings secret, and much later it was adopted by Wiccans (see pp.264–267).

a	b	c	d	e	f	g	h
ſ	ſ	ſ	ſ	ſ	ſ	ſ	ſ
i	k	l	m	n	o	p	q
ſ	ſ	ſ	ſ	ſ	ſ	ſ	ſ
r	s	t	u	x	y	z	&
ſ	ſ	ſ	ſ	ſ	ſ	ſ	ſ

The Theban alphabet is shown here in the polymath Johannes Trithemius's 16th-century work *Polygraphia*.

One influential occult philosopher who clashed with Christian authorities was the German scholar Agrippa, who is considered to have made the first important distinction between ritual magic and the combined disciplines of natural magic and natural philosophy in his 1530 text translated as “On the Uncertainty and Vanity of the Arts and Sciences: An Invective Declamation”. Agrippa was a skeptic, which in philosophical terms means that he pursued

his studies with a spirit of inquiry, rethinking all accepted knowledge. He widely promoted natural magic and tried to unite different strands of knowledge in works such as *De occulta philosophia libri tres*, and believed that God's divinity underpinned everything, including beneficial magic. Mirandola and Italian scholar Marsilio Ficino also belonged to this Hermetic-influenced world of expansive inquiry, and Agrippa inspired other figures, such as Giordano Bruno (see p.134), with his Hermetic ideas.